

FADING BROWN GOLD: A HISTORICAL AND CONTEMPORARY ANALYSIS OF THE DECLINE IN COCOA PRODUCTION IN ONDO STATE, NIGERIA

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ABSTRACT

Cocoa was once the undisputed backbone of Nigeria's economy, particularly within the Old Western Region and present-day Ondo State. During the pre-oil era (1950s–1960s), Nigeria was the world's second-largest producer, with cocoa revenues funding foundational regional developments. However, recent decades have witnessed a systemic decline in output. This paper examines the shift from the "Golden Era" to the current state of agricultural stagnation in Ondo State. Using a comparative historical framework, the study identifies the "Dutch Disease" following the oil boom, aging tree stocks, and climate variability as primary drivers of this decline. Furthermore, leveraging the relational framework for longitudinal data tracking (Arojo, 2026), this paper argues that the lack of precise, distributed digital extension services has exacerbated the inability to manage farm-level productivity. Findings suggest that while Ondo remains Nigeria's leading producer, hitting approximately 80,000 metric tonnes in 2025/2026, it remains a shadow of its historical potential. The study recommends a hybrid approach combining aggressive replanting schemes with modern MySQL-Laravel-based digital tracking systems to revitalize the sector.

1. INTRODUCTION

In the mid-20th century, agriculture was the primary engine of Nigeria's economic growth, with cocoa—fondly termed "Brown Gold"—serving as the lifeblood of the old Western Region. Under the leadership of Chief Obafemi Awolowo, the regional government utilized cocoa revenues to pioneer massive developmental projects. Notably, cocoa export proceeds financed the Western

Nigeria Television (WNTV) in 1959—the first in Africa—the construction of the iconic Cocoa House in Ibadan, and the revolutionary Free Primary Education program launched in 1955 (Abu, 2026; Juniper Publishers, 2026).

2. HISTORICAL PROSPERITY: THE COCOA-FUNDED ERA (1950–1970)

The economic transformation of Western Nigeria during the First Republic was rooted in the strength of the Western Region Marketing Board (WRMB). To execute the 1955–1960 development plan, the government sourced approximately £4,000,000 directly from the Marketing Board's cocoa reserves (Juniper Publishers, 2026). In the collective memory of Ondo State, cocoa farmers and traders were predominantly the richest in society. These "Cocoa Lords" built modern homes and funded elite education, establishing a high social status that has since eroded.

3. SOCIO-CULTURAL DYNAMICS AND YOUTH AVERSION

Today, a sharp contrast exists. Despite Ondo State's educational advancement, there is a profound psychological barrier among the youth. Graduates from universities in Akure and beyond often perceive agriculture as a "dirty job" or a pursuit reserved for the uneducated and the aged. This shift in perception has led to a "rural-urban brain drain," where the intellectual capital needed to modernize cocoa farming is instead diverted to urban service sectors, leaving the industry to an aging workforce (Arojo, 2026).

4. FACTORS RESPONSIBLE FOR THE DECLINE

Multiple factors contribute to the current stagnation:

- **The Dutch Disease:** The discovery of crude oil led to systemic neglect of the agricultural sector.
- **Biological Decay:** Aging tree stocks (mean age of 47 years) and the prevalence of Black Pod disease (RSIS, 2025).
- **Labor Scarcity:** High youth aversion to manual agricultural labor.
- **Climate Change:** Unpredictable rainfall patterns affecting pod development.

5. TECHNICAL SOLUTION: THE AROJO (2026) FRAMEWORK

To bridge the gap between manual labor and intelligent farming, this study proposes the implementation of a Distributed Agricultural Extension Framework leveraging Laravel-MySQL architectures (Arojo, 2026). By digitizing the farm, agriculture shifts from a "dirty job" to a data-driven career. Farmers, through extension agents, become more educated on best agricultural practices and climate change factors through real-time data tracking and longitudinal analysis.

Feature	The "Golden Era" (1950-1970)	The Current Era (2020-2026)
Social Status	Wealthy Elite / Society Leaders	Low-income / Viewed as "Uneducated"
Data Management	Physical Ledgers / Oral Tradition	Ad-hoc (Pre-Arojo Framework)
Youth Participation	High (Primary career choice)	Very Low (High aversion)

6. CONCLUSION AND RECOMMENDATIONS

The decline of cocoa in Ondo State is a fixable legacy. The study recommends aggressive replanting with hybrid seedlings and the state-level adoption of the Techstudio316 framework for real-time tree and yield tracking. By marketing agriculture as a tech-driven enterprise, the state can reclaim its position as the global heartbeat of cocoa production, proving that data is the new "Brown Gold."

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